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Haotian Zheng

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Summary of Research Interests

- Financial Well-being
- Financial Capability Theory (and Interventions)
- Social Policy
- Asset-based Theory (and Interventions)
- Low-income Populations

Academic Appointments

Fall 2025 **Assistant Professor**
School of Social Welfare, SUNY-Stony Brook

Education & Certification

Education

2025 PhD in Social Work
Brown School
Washington University, St. Louis
Dissertation: Conceptualizing and Measuring Financial Capability and Its Association with Financial Well-Being
Chair: Michael Sherraden

2023 Master of Arts, Economics
Dept. of Economics
University of Missouri-Columbia

2019 Master of Social Work
School of Social Work
University of Michigan

2017 LL.B., Sociology / Social Work
School of Sociology
Central China Normal University (CCNU)

2016 BISP Student, Sociology
Dept. of Sociology
University of California-Berkeley

2015 Exchange Student, Psychol. Counseling
Dept. of Psychol. Counseling
National Taipei University of Education

Certificates

2024 Artificial Intelligence and Big Data Analytics Certificate
Brown School, Washington University

2021 Completed Coursework in Graduate Certificate in Quantitative Data Analysis
(Certification not issued due to departmental policy)
Washington University

2019 Financial Social Work Certificate
Center for Financial Social Work

2019 Human Service Management Certificate
University of Michigan School of Social Work

2018 Online Certificate in Political Social Work
University of Michigan School of Social Work

Publication

Journal Articles

[J19] **Zheng, H.**, Huang, J., & Sherraden, M. (2025). Historical Harms and Racial Wealth Inequality: Evidence from Homeownership and Retirement Savings Accounts. *Journal of Economics, Race, and Policy*.

[J18] **Zheng, H.**, Roll, S., & Despard, M. (2024). Job Loss During COVID-19 on Early Retirement Withdrawals: A Moderated-Mediation Analysis. *Journal of Consumer Affairs*.

[J17] Roll, S., **Zheng, H.**, Hamilton, L., Despard, M., & Chun, Y. (forthcoming). The Impacts of the Child Tax Credit on Financial Resilience and the Use of High-Cost Financial Resources: Evidence from a Panel Survey. *Journal of the Society for Social Work and Research*.

[J16] Shanks, T., Huang, J., Elliott, W., **Zheng, H.**, Clancy, M., & Sherraden, M. (2024). A Policy Platform to Deliver Black Reparations: Building on Evidence from Child Development Account. *The Russell Sage Foundation Journal of the Social Sciences*, *10*(3). https://doi.org/https://doi.org/10.7758/RSF.2024.10.3.05

[J15] Chen, J. H., **Zheng, H.**, Drake, B., & Jonson-Reid, M. (2023). Explaining adolescent problematic behavior: An application of the Family Stress Model and the Family Investment Model. *Journal of Child and Family Studies*, *32*(7).

[J14] Jabbari, J., Terada, T., **Zheng, H.**, & Roll, S. (2024). Student Loan Policies and Payments during the COVID-19 Pandemic: Closing the Gap or Widening Inequalities? *Journal of Student Financial Aid*, *53*(2). https://doi.org/https://doi.org/10.55504/0884-9153.1804

[J13] Despard, M., **Zheng, H.**, & Fox-Ditcher, S. (2023). Access to Employer Benefits and Financial Well-Being among Frontline Healthcare Workers. *Compensation & Benefits Review*.

[J12] Jabbari, J., **Zheng, H.**, Roll, S., Auguste, D., & Heller, O. (2023). How Did Reskilling during the COVID-19 Pandemic Relate and Entrepreneurship in Optimism? Barriers, Opportunities, and Implications for Equity. *Journal of Family and Economic Issues*. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10834-023-09906-y

[J11] Elliott, W., Sorensen, N., **Zheng, H.**, & O'Brien, M. (2023). Early Award Scholarship Program Results in Improved Attendance and State Math Test Scores for Students from Lower-Income Households. *Economies*, *11*(3). https://doi.org/10.3390/economies11030082

[J10] Chen, Z., O'Brien, M., Nielsen, S., **Zheng, H.**, & Starks, B. (2023). A Cross-Sectional Examination of Educational Expectation Among Welfare Users in an Asset Building Program. *Global Social Welfare: Research, Policy & Practice*. https://doi.org/10.1007/s40609-023-00263-0

[J9] **Zheng, H.**, Elliott, W., & O'Brien, M. (2022). Using Children's Savings Accounts and Early Awards to Build College Savings among Welfare Recipients: The Case of Promise Scholars. *Journal of Poverty*, *26*(4). https://doi.org/10.1080/10875549.2021.1910105

[J8] **Zheng, H.**, Harris, E., Elliott, W., & O'Brien, M. (2022). The Role of Children's Savings Accounts in Promoting Savings for College Among Welfare Recipients: The Case of Harold Alfond College Challenge (HACC). *Journal of Family and Economic Issues*. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10834-022-09837-0

[J7] Chen, J.-H., Wu, C.-F., & **Zheng, H.**. (2022). Who Stays Poor and Who Doesn't? An Analysis Based on Joint Assessment of Income and Assets. *Journal of Social Policy*. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0047279422000563

[J6] Elliott, W., **Zheng, H.**, Sabol, T., & O'Brien, M. (2021). A step toward measuring children's college-bound identity in children's savings accounts programs: The case of promise scholars. *Children and Youth Services Review*, *121*. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.childyouth.2020.105791

[J5] Elliott, W., Sorensen, N., O'Brien, M., Chen, Z., Starks, B., & **Zheng, H.**. (2021). The Impact of Grocery Store Rewards Cards on Saving and Asset Accumulation in Children's Savings Account Programs. *Journal of the Society for Social Work and Research*. https://doi.org/10.1086/717105

[J4] Friedline, T., Wood, A. K., Wheatley, M., Oh, S., & **Zheng, H.**. (2021). Doubling Down on Racial Capitalism during COVID-19: Qualitative Interviews with Bank Employees. *The ANNALS of the American Academy of Political and Social Science*, *698*(1). https://doi.org/10.1177/00027162211061277

[J3] Chen, Z., Elliott, W., Wang, K., Zhang, A., & **Zheng, H.**. (2020). Examining parental educational expectations in one of the oldest children's savings account programs in the country: The Harold Alfond College Challenge. *Children and Youth Services Review*, *108*. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.childyouth.2019.104582

[J2] Franklin, C., Guz, S., Zhang, A., Kim, J., **Zheng, H.**, Hai, A. H., Cho, Y. J., & Shen, L. (2022). Solution-Focused Brief Therapy for Students in Schools: A Comparative Meta-Analysis of the U.S. and Chinese Literature. *Journal of the Society for Social Work and Research*, *13*(2). https://doi.org/10.1086/712169

[J1] Wang, K., Zhang, A., **Zheng, H.**, Kim, Y., & Padilla, Y. (2021). Proximal Social Determinants of Adolescents' Health: The Importance of Everyday Life Circumstances. *Youth & Society*, *53*(6). https://doi.org/10.1177/0044118X20918436

Under Consideration

[U3] Conroy, S., **Zheng, H.**, Roll, S., & Despard, M. (Under review). Volatility or Variability? Redirecting the Management Conversation on Pay Volatility.

[U2] Sherraden, M., **Zheng, H.**, Shanks, T., & Huang, J. (Under review). Historical Harms by Race in the United States: A Family Level Assessment.

[U1] Bartosiak, A., Loibl, C., **Zheng, H.**, & Roll, S. (Revised & Resubmitted). To What Extent Did Social Media Use Contribute to Financial Hardship One Year into the COVID-19 Pandemic? Examining the Role of Fear of Missing Out.

Policy Briefs, Internal Reports, & Other Research Outputs

[R7] **Zheng, H.**, Roll, S., & Despard, M. (2025). *Financial shocks, emergency savings, and hardship among low-wage workers* (CSD Research Brief No. 25-48). Washington University, Center for Social Development. https://doi.org/10.7936/30x2-p507

[R6] Chy, S., **Zheng, H.**, Roll, S., & Despard, M. (2025a). *Buy now, pay later and alternative financial service use among low-wage workers* (CSD Research Brief No. 25-28). Washington University, Center for Social Development.

[R5] Elliott, W., & **Zheng, H.**. (2023, November). *What If Education Isn't the Great Equalizer? Reimagining Financial Aid from a Financial Capability Perspective, the Role of Children's Savings Accounts and Assets*. University of Michigan Center on Assets, Education and Inclusion. Ann Arbor, MI. https://aedi.ssw.umich.edu/sites/default/files/documents/Reports/unequal-returns/unequal-returns-full-report.pdf

[R4] Elliott, W., **Zheng, H.**, O'Brien, M., & Choi, T. (2023). Children's Savings Accounts and Rural Children's College Expectations: The Case of Kickstart Newaygo County. *Sociology Mind*, *13*(1). https://doi.org/10.4236/sm.2023.131003

[R3] **Zheng, H.**, Elliott, W., & O'Brien, M. (2022a). The Importance of Parent/Child Communications About Children's Savings Accounts for Developing a College-Bound Identity. *Advances in Social Sciences Research Journal*, *9*(9). https://doi.org/10.14738/assrj.99.13030

[R2] **Zheng, H.**, Starks, B., Ellis, J., O'Brien, M., & Elliott, W. (2020). An Examination of Parental College Expectations' Mediating Role between Children's Savings Accounts and Children's Educational Attainment by Income Level. *Sociology Mind*, *10*(3). https://doi.org/10.4236/sm.2020.103011

[R1] O'Brien, M., **Zheng, H.**, & Elliott, W. (2020, September). *2020 Participation and Savings Patterns in the Wabash County Promise Scholarship Program: The First Three Years*. University of Michigan Center on Assets, Education and Inclusion. Ann Arbor, MI. https://aedi.ssw.umich.edu/sites/default/files/publications/6%5C%20Paper%5C_Savings%5C%20Report%5C%20First%5C%203%5C%20Years%5C_published%5C%20on%5C%20AEDI%5C%20website.pdf

Presentation

[C11] **Zheng, H.**, Roll, S., Guangli, Z., & Hamilton, L. Guaranteed Income as a Tool for Financial Liberation and Debt Reduction [Peer-Reviewed]. In: In *2025 APPAM Fall Research Conference*. Seattle, WA, 2025.

[C10] Chy, S., **Zheng, H.**, Roll, S., & Despard, M. Buy Now, Pay Later and Alternative Financial Service Usage among Low-Wage Workers [Peer-Reviewed]. In: In *ACCI 2025 Annual Conference*. Pittsburg, PA, 2025.

[C9] Conroy, S., Roll, S., **Zheng, H.**, & Despard, M. Conditions of Pay Volatility's Negative Health Effects for Vulnerable Workers [Peer-Reviewed]. In: In *Acaedmy of Management meetings*. Chicago, IL, 2024.

[C8] Ferris, D., Ocampo, M. G., & **Zheng, H.**. Social Work Policy Engagement in the U.S. [Peer-Reviewed]. In: In *13th European Conference for Social Work Research*. Vilnius, Lithuania, 2024.

[C7] **Zheng, H.**, Huang, J., & Sherraden, M. Historical Harm and Contemporary Wealth Disparities [Peer-Reviewed]. In: In *2024 Society for Social Work and Research Conference*. Washington, D.C., 2024.

[C6] **Zheng, H.**, Despard, M., & Roll, S. COVID-19 Related Job Loss and Early Withdrawals from Retirement Accounts: Mediation by Financial Hardships and Financial Well-being [Peer-Reviewed]. In: In *ACCI 2023 Annual Conference*. Las Vegas, NV, 2023.

[C5] **Zheng, H.**, Despard, M., & Roll, S. COVID-19 Related Job Loss and Early Withdrawals from Retirement Accounts: Mediation by Financial Hardships and Financial Well-being [Peer-Reviewed]. In: In *2023 Society for Social Work and Research Conference*. Phoenix, AZ, 2023.

[C4] Sherraden, M., **Zheng, H.**, Shanks, T., Shanadora, B., & Huang, J. Historical Harm by Race in the United States [Peer-Reviewed]. In: In *2023 Society for Social Work and Research Conference*. Phoenix, AZ, 2023.

[C3] Despard, M., **Zheng, H.**, Fox-Dicheer, S., & Gilbert, K. Benefits and Financial Security among Frontline healthcare Workers [Peer-Reviewed]. In: In *2022 APPAM Fall Research Conference*. Washington, D.C., 2022.

[C2] **Zheng, H.**, Elliott, W., & O'Brien, M. The Importance of Parent/Child Communication about Children's Savings Accounts for Developing a College-Bound Identity [Peer-Reviewed]. In: In *2021 APPAM Fall Research Conference*. Austin, TX, 2022.

[C1] Bartosiak, A., Loibl, C., **Zheng, H.**, & Roll, S. The Association of Fear of Missing Out, Social Media Use and Credit Card Debt [Peer-Reviewed]. In: In *ACCI 2022 Annual Conference*. Clearwater Beach, FL, 2022.

Media Coverage

Schoenherr, N. (2024). COVID-19 Job Losses Impacted Early Withdrawal from Retirement Accounts. *The Source*. https://source.washu.edu/2024/09/covid-19-job-losses-impacted-early-withdrawal-from-retirement-accounts/

Henderson, A. Y. (2024). Wash U researchers say child savings accounts can be used to deliver reparations. *National Public Radio - St. Louis*. https://www.stlpr.org/race-identity-and-faith/2024-07-08/washington-university-researchers-child-savings-reparations

Shivaji, S. (2023). Financial insecurity common among frontline health care workers during COVID-19, research finds. *Medical Xpress*. https://medicalxpress.com/news/2023-10-financial-insecurity-common-frontline-health.html

Friedline, T. (2020). How Banks Are Exploiting the Coronavirus Crisis for Profit. *The American Prospect*. https://prospect.org/coronavirus/how-banks-are-exploiting-the-crisis-for-profit/

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Grants, Fellowships, & Awards

2025 Grand Challenges for Social Work Honorable Mention
2023 Teaching Excellence Award for Doctoral Teaching Fellow of Brown School
2022 American Council on Consumer Interests Small Grant ($2,500)
2020 MRDRC HRS Workshop Award($550)
2020 Global Independent Study Grant ($2,000)
2016 Excellent Student Awards in CCNU
2015 Excellent Award of Social Work Case Competition in Hubei Province

Teaching

2022 Fall **Teaching Assistant** of MPH 5230 Applied Linear Regression
Brown School of Social Work, Washington University
Supervised by RJ Waken, Ph.D.
Activities: Led two lectures, graded three assignments and final papers, and held weekly office hours

2022 Fall **Teaching Assistant** of SWCR 5007 Research Methods with Statistical Applications
Brown School of Social Work, Washington University
Supervised by Proscovia Nabunya, Ph.D.
Activities: Led three lectures, graded three assignments and final papers, and held weekly office hours

2022 Spring **Teaching Assistant** of SWSP 5842 Social Policy Analysis & Evaluation
Brown School of Social Work, Washington University
Supervised by Daniel Ferris, Ph.D. and Molly Pearson
Activities: Led one lecture, graded two assignments and final papers, and held weekly office hours

Services & Professional Experiences

Ad-Hoc Reviewer:

- Journal of Consumer Affairs
- Journal of Child and Family Studies
- Journal of Financial Counseling and Planning
- Journal of Financial and Economic Issues
- American Council on Consumer Interests Annual Conference
- Compensation & Benefits Review
- Heliyon
- Journal of Infrastructure, Policy and Development
- Journal of Student Financial Aid
- Journal of Psychosocial Oncology
- International Journal of Mental Health Promotion

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Services

2019 **Auction Site Manager**
Douglas Davies Library Auction, University of Michigan-SSW

2019 **Project Lead**
United Way of Washtenaw County Volunteer Landscape Evaluation, University of Michigan Ginsberg Center Community Technical Assistance Collaboration

2019 **Member**
Congressional Research Institute for Social Work & Policy: Social Work Day on the Hill

2019 **Interprofessional Student Member**
+Lab at Center on Positive Organizations, University of Michigan Ross School of Business

2015 **Data Analyst**
Social Work Clinical Case Competition of Hubei Province

2015 **International Volunteer**
Nepal's Suicide Prevention and Mental Health Center

Professional Experiences

2018 **Peer Mentor**
University of Michigan-SSW Mentorship Program

2018 **Intern**
Department of Services Management, Taikang Healthcare Investment Holdings Co. Ltd

2018 **Intern**
Coordinated Funding, Washtenaw County Office of Community and Economic Development (OCED)

2016 **Intern**
Summer Youth Program, Wuhan Hongshan District Jinhe Park Youth Space

2015 **Intern**
Community Organization Incubation, Wuhan Boya Social Work Service Center